North, and now in Karnataka and Bengal, have some history of sectarian identity politics. This is vote-growing on the back of an 'aspirational class plus Hindutva,' argued Mrug. 'At a time of great social flux, a party that has a sharper ideology and positioning compared to others who are bits of everything, like the Congress, always looks more attractive.'

The BJP's early dominant image of a city-based party was a vestige of the Jan Sangh era—an image that stuck long after its use-by date. Even in 1989, when the BJP won only eight Lok Sabha seats in UP, all of these wins were in rurban or rural areas. Most of those early BJP inroads had two things in common: a rural base with a large Muslim population and communal tensions: Bareilly (rurban and with communal tension), Aonla (large Muslim population and rurban), Saidpur (large Muslim population), Kaiserganj (large Muslim population and rural), Etah (rural western UP and home to the BJP's first OBC chief minister in UP, Kalyan Singh), Jhansi (rurban), Jaunpur (rural) and Robertsganj (rural). The party had won urban seats like Kanpur and Lucknow as early as 1967, when it won 100 UP assembly seats under the leadership of Deendayal Upadhyaya. However, by 1989, its mainstay was rurban UP, especially pockets of communal polarisation. 'Wherever there is a rural population and a history of Muslim dominance, it automatically becomes a foundational ground for the BJP,' Mrug pointed out. 'If it is a rurban space like Bareilly, that is "sone pe suhaga" [the glitter on the gold].'[7]

In that sense, UP 1991 was an early prototype for UP 2014 and 2019, which lay at the heart of the new model that Amit Shah and Modi built. In 1991, the party won over half the seats in UP in an epochal election in which the BSP's Mayawati herself lost from Muzaffarnagar to a BJP candidate, Mangal Lal Premi. That initial BJP upsurge as a major electoral force in the 1990s was built on the conjunction of three forces: caste realignment and the co-option of OBCs led by Kalyan Singh, the creation of a new Hindu political identity and a robust party cadre.

The Ram Janmabhoomi movement dated back to 1984, but it was only after the V.P. Singh government announced the Mandal Commission Action Plan for giving reservations to OBCs on 15 August 1990 that L.K. Advani's Rath Yatra took shape. Lord Ram